

SOUTH AFRICA divided

PROTEST AGAINST APARTHEID

Apartheid in South Africa was an extreme form of racial segregation in which the white government categorized the population into “whites,” “coloreds,” and “blacks.” Apartheid, an Afrikaans word meaning “apartness,” designated the minority whites as the ruling class, and held the nonwhite population in poverty and servitude through restrictive laws of racial segregation.

Although black women held the least political power in South Africa, they acted as catalysts in mobilizing the masses, staging some of the most successful protests against apartheid. In 1913, the South African government tried to extend hated pass laws—which already applied to men—to women. Passes provided proof of where a person was allowed to go, restricting black people’s movement outside of segregated areas. Activist and public speaker Charlotte Maxeke led a campaign against the extension, which resulted in the government restricting passes to black men in 1920.

Women and the ANC

In 1912, the African National Congress (ANC) united various African groups to fight for black voting rights and, from the 1940s, to end apartheid. Women were not allowed to join the ANC until 1943 when the ANC Women’s League (ANCWL) was formed. Then, in 1954, Rachel “Ray” Simons and

Hilda Bernstein, both communist party members, created the Federation of South African Women (FEDSAW), the first broad-based women’s group.

In 1952, the ANC and ANCWL initiated the Defiance Campaign Against Unjust Laws—the first large-scale, multiracial mobilization against apartheid, during which

over 8,000 were arrested. Women were pivotal to the protest. Trade unionist Bibi “Asa” Dawood recruited about 800 volunteers for the campaign, and Lilian Ngoyi made a name for herself as a powerful speaker and organizer. In 1955, the government once again announced legislation for mandatory passes for women. On August 9, 1956, 20,000 women

responded by marching on the presidential Union Buildings in Pretoria. Although women were eventually made to carry passes, the protest made such an impression that August 9 became South African Women’s Day.

The struggle to end apartheid was long and bitter, but in 1994 it was finally abolished—a result that could never have been realized without women’s involvement. Women have continued to take part in South African politics since 1994; Winnie Mandela (known as “Mother of the Nation”), who was a leading yet controversial anti-apartheid activist, even went on to serve as a member of parliament.

50%
of working black
women were
employed in white
homes in 1982

▼ Congress of colors

Multiracial members of the ANC Women’s League march in protest at Germiston, South Africa, in 1956, during the Defiance Campaign.



► Unity in diversity

As this 1984 Dutch poster for Women Against Apartheid shows, international women’s rights activists of all colors opposed apartheid.